

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

CAPITOL HILL

House GOP report targets Cheney

Separate panel probing Jan. 6 seeks prosecution of vocal Trump critic, reinforcing the president-elect's desire to punish his perceived enemies

By Lisa Mascaro
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Wrapping up their own investigation on the Jan. 6, 2021, Capitol attack, House Republicans have concluded it's former GOP Rep. Liz Cheney who should be prosecuted for probing

what happened when then-President Donald Trump sent his mob of supporters as Congress was certifying the 2020 election. The findings issued Tuesday show the Republican Party working to reinforce Trump's desire to punish his perceived enemies including Cheney and members

of the Jan. 6 committee that the president-elect has said should be in jail. House Administration Committee Chairman Barry Loudermilk, R-Ga., wrote, "Until we hold accountable those responsible, and reform our institutions, we will not fully regain trust."

The panel Republicans' 128-page interim report arrives as Trump is preparing his return to the White House and working to staff his administration with officials at the highest levels, including Kash Patel as FBI director, who appear like-minded in his efforts at retribution. Trump also vows to pardon people who were convicted for roles in the riot at the Capitol.

Turn to Cheney, Page 9

PARDONS COMING? President Joe Biden is considering issuing preemptive pardons to spare some Democratic members of Congress and others from President-elect Donald Trump's political wrath. But several of the people involved have said they are neither seeking nor want pardons from the president.

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Board ramps up pressure on CEO

Either fire Martinez or offer settlement, meeting agenda says

By Sarah Macaraeg and Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago Board of Education called a special meeting for Friday with two explicit options to either fire schools chief Pedro Martinez or offer him a settlement.

The meeting initially scheduled for 11 a.m. at a Chicago Public Schools administrative building on the South Side was moved to 5:45 p.m., according to the board's site, after a district spokesperson noted on Wednesday afternoon that a vote to fire Martinez could not occur without a revision to the agenda.

Wednesday evening, two additional reports from the outside counsel were then added to the agenda: to one, "approve settlement with chief officer" or two, "approve termination of chief officer."

For both reports, a note was added that "this matter may be moved forward for final action or deferred for final action at a future Board meeting."

The potential vote to remove the CEO, as the Chicago Teachers Union has called on board

Turn to Schools, Page 4



BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

Crane mishap fouls river



Stephen Meyer, above, a volunteer coordinator with the nonprofit Urban Rivers, cleans up perlite, a white insulation material used in construction, from the bank of the Chicago River at Division Street on Wednesday after demolition work Saturday at the former Chicago Tribune Freedom Center sent debris into the water. Videos shared on social media showed a crane bring down a wall as construction continues on the site of the new Bally's Chicago Casino, causing the non-hazardous material to spill into the river and bring protective netting down with it. A multiphase cleanup by the construction company is underway, and the Metropolitan Water Reclamation District of Greater Chicago said it will monitor the site. Cleanup includes the installation of a barge that has been positioned at the site to prevent additional demolition material from entering the river. **Chicagoland, Page 2**

Vaccination rates for flu, COVID-19 down

In Chicago, 'an uphill battle' as winter starts

By Sylvan Lebrun
Chicago Tribune

Vaccination rates in Chicago so far this winter for seasonal respiratory infections like COVID-19 and the flu are slightly down from last year, which public health officials say could be a result of disinformation and "vaccine fatigue" since the pandemic.

Only approximately 10.7% of Chicagoans had received the updated 2024-25 COVID-19 vaccine as of Dec. 14, while 22.5% had gotten their flu shot, according to data from the Chicago Department of Public Health.

Compared with the end of the second full week of December 2023, vaccination rates for both the flu and COVID-19 have decreased by more than a full percentage point, according to city data. Approximately 36,500 fewer Chicago residents have received their flu vaccine so far this year, while about 46,000 fewer people have received their COVID-19 vaccine.

Public health experts say that these low vaccination rates can partially be attributed to a general weariness surrounding vaccines after the crisis of the COVID-19 pandemic, as well as increased misinformation regarding vaccines' efficacy and risk.

Turn to Vaccines, Page 5

MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

Ex-lobbyist tells jury he knew of no bribery deal

By Jason Meisner and Megan Crepeau
Chicago Tribune

After nine weeks of prosecution witnesses, defense attorneys in the blockbuster corruption trial of ex-House Speaker Michael Madigan and his longtime confidante Michael McClain began presenting their case to jurors Wednesday by calling someone who, until quite recently, was expected to testify for the government.

That witness was Stephen Selcke, a retired AT&T Illinois government affairs officer who said Wednesday he knew of no explicit arrangement to hire former state Rep. Eddie Acevedo, a Madigan ally, in exchange for the speaker's support of key legislation the telecommunications giant wanted in Springfield.



Former AT&T insider Stephen Selcke leaves the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse on Wednesday after testifying in ex-House Speaker Michael Madigan's corruption trial. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

On cross-examination, though, Selcke repeatedly acknowledged that AT&T put Acevedo on a \$2,500-a-month subcontract solely because McClain, who was known to be an emissary for Madigan, asked them to, and not doing so might have risked irritating the speaker's office.

Whether that legally qualifies as a bribe will soon be up to jurors.

Prosecutors formally rested their case in chief early Wednesday after 30 days of testimony that stretched over three months.

They presented about 150 wire-tapped calls and undercover video recordings and put more than 50 witnesses on the stand, including two men who wore wires for the FBI: former ComEd executive Fidel Marquez and, perhaps most memorably, ex-Ald. Daniel Solis.

Defense attorneys are likely to call far fewer witnesses, but with a break next week for the Christmas holiday, it appears the defense phase of the trial will

Turn to Madigan, Page 2

Charges dropped for Oak Lawn cop

Cook County prosecutors dropped charges Wednesday against an Oak Lawn police officer charged in connection with the violent arrest of a then-17-year-old Bridgeview teen in July 2022. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

